

Theoretical Reflection

This study, extends resource dilution theory and shows that sibship size effects in Palestine are not uniform, but conditional, mediated, and norm-governed.

Quantitative results show that additional school-aged siblings reduce literacy, numeracy, and some cognitive outcomes through diluted parental time, attention, and financial resources.

Qualitative findings extend this by showing that parents do not allocate resources randomly or equally. Instead, they manage scarcity through sufficiency thresholds, critical-stage prioritization, and birth-order delegation.

Further the results shows that these allocation rules are embedded in locality-specific cultural logics: rural parents frame larger sibship as collective resilience and shared responsibility, while urban parents emphasize “quality over quantity,” educational investment, time, and space.

Resource dilution is not only a mechanical reduction of resources per child; in Palestine, it operates as a socially structured and culturally justified allocation process, shaped by gender norms, SES, locality, and community expectations.

Conclusion

This study explores the effects of the number of school-aged siblings on children's literacy/numeracy skills and mental health; this study also explored potential mechanisms that contribute to or mediate this effect.

A larger number of school-aged siblings negatively impacts literacy and numeracy skills in children, especially among boys, urban households, and lower-income families. Non-Cognitive aspects of mental health, like memory, are negatively affected by sibling competition for resources.

- The social benefits of having siblings may reduce anxiety, showing a mixed effect on overall mental well-being.
- Highlights the dual nature of sibling influence on child development: cognitive disadvantages vs. social support.
- Resource Dilution Theory should consider parenting quality alongside resource availability.
- Need for educational and mental health support for children in larger families, focusing on urban and low-income households.
- Found that violent discipline (parenting style) as a mechanism that mediates the relationship between sibship size and mental health, with more siblings leading to increased use of harsh discipline, leading to a higher occurrence of mental health issues, highlighting the need for policy to protect children from domestic violence.
- Parents actively manage scarcity through structured allocation rules, rather than passive dilution. These strategies are deeply shaped by cultural norms, locality type, and gendered expectations, explaining why similar sibship sizes yield different outcomes across households.
- Policies should also consider/focus on the numeracy skills for children.